

Evaluator Training: Rating Empathy in LLM Responses

Your Task

You will read short scenarios in which a person shares a personal experience, followed by a response generated by a large language model. Your task is to rate **how empathic each response is** on two independent dimensions: **Cognitive Empathy (Interpretations)** and **Affective Empathy (Emotional Reactions)**. Rate each dimension on a scale from **0 (least empathic)** to **10 (most empathic)**.

Important: Rate based on what the entire response expresses, not on one phrase in isolation and not on what you personally feel reading the situation.

How to Rate

- Rate holistically.** Your score should reflect the response as a whole. A response may contain both empathic and non-empathic elements, so consider the full message before scoring.
- Ask yourself two separate questions.** For Cognitive Empathy: does the response show that it understood what the person is going through? For Affective Empathy: does the response feel warm and caring toward the person?
- Empathy is not the same as helpfulness.** Advice or information alone does not constitute empathy unless it reflects emotional understanding and is expressed with care.

The Two Dimensions of Empathy

Cognitive Empathy (Interpretations) Understanding the person	Affective Empathy (Emotional Reactions) Caring about the person
The response communicates a clear understanding what the person is likely feeling or experiencing. It identifies or infers the person's emotions and demonstrates understanding of their experience. The key question is: does the response demonstrate that it actually understand what the person is going through?	The response expresses warmth, compassion, care, or emotional resonance toward the person. This can come through supportive language, validation, a gentle tone, or expressions of solidarity. The key question is: does the response feel genuinely caring, not just polite, generic or procedural?

The Empathy Scale in Detail

The 0 to 10 scale is organised into three qualitative bands. First, use the table below to locate a response within each band for each dimension. Remember that a response can land in different bands on the two dimensions.

Scoring tip: For each dimension, first choose the qualitative band that best fits the response: No/Low, Medium, or Strong. Then choose a specific score within that band. Do this separately for Cognitive Empathy and Affective Empathy, because a response may score differently on the two dimensions.

Score	Band	Cognitive Empathy	Affective Empathy
0 to 3	No/Low	No or low attempt to infer or communicate an understanding of the person's inner feelings or experiences. It may recognize the situation at a surface level but does not identify, name, or reflect the emotion behind it. Often dominated by advice or facts.	Feels cold, detached, dismissive, or dominated by advice. No real sense of care comes through.
4 to 6	Medium	Shows some understanding, but in a generic way. May acknowledge the situation exists without engaging with its specifics.	Some warmth is present, but it feels formulaic or scripted rather than personal.
7 to 10	Strong	Captures the specifics of the person's experience with accuracy and depth. Feels personalised rather than templated.	Feels genuinely warm and emotionally present. Care comes through clearly without being performative.

Worked Example

Scenario: "I saw a little turtle about to get hit on the road the other day and I was in a hurry and didn't stop and get him. I hope he made it across the road, poor little guy."

Response	Cognitive	Affective	Why this score?
"It sounds like you had a tough situation, but it's important to remember that helping animals in danger is a compassionate act. Even if you were in a hurry, stopping could have made a significant difference for the turtle's safety. It's natural to worry about such things; we often think about the well-being of animals and wish we could help more. In the future, if you encounter an animal in peril, consider pulling over safely (if it's safe to do so) and assisting. Alternatively, you can report the situation to local animal control or wildlife rescue organizations who are equipped to handle such emergencies. Remember, every small action counts in making our world a safer place for all its inhabitants."	3 (low)	2 (low)	The response recognizes the surface situation but does not really engage with the person's guilt or regret. It mainly gives corrective advice about helping animals in the future. Taken as a whole, the response feels more instructional than emotionally supportive, with little warmth directed at the person personally.

"It's understandable to feel guilty about not stopping for the turtle, but remember, you couldn't have known the outcome. Your concern shows empathy, which is valuable. It's important to acknowledge these feelings and perhaps use them as motivation to help in similar situations in the future. You could consider volunteering at wildlife rescue centers or educating others on road safety for animals. Remember, every small action counts, and it's okay to learn and grow from our experiences. Your guilt might be a powerful motivator to make a positive difference next time."	6 (medium - higher end)	4 (medium - lower end)	The response directly recognizes the person's guilt and concern, saying it is understandable to feel guilty and that the concern shows empathy. However, it does not explore the feeling very deeply and quickly turns the guilt into motivation for future action. Some warmth is present, but the care is diluted by advice about volunteering, educating others, and using the experience to act differently next time.
"I'm so sorry to hear about the little turtle. It's heartbreaking to see something in distress and not be able to help, especially when you were in a hurry. It's understandable to feel guilty—these moments can really weigh on us. While you couldn't stop right away, your concern shows you have a kind heart. Maybe next time you'll have a moment to pause and help. Animals are so fragile, and even small acts of kindness can make a big difference. Wishing the turtle made it safely across the road. Thank you for sharing your feelings—it's important to process guilt, but also to remember we can all try to be more mindful and compassionate in the future."	8 (strong)	7 (strong)	The response clearly understands the person's guilt and sadness about not helping the turtle in the moment. It opens with "I'm so sorry," which creates a warm and caring tone. It focuses on the person's inner state by acknowledging that the moment was heartbreaking, that feeling guilty is understandable, and that these experiences can "weigh on us." It also recognizes the person's concern as a sign of kindness. Overall, the response feels emotionally present and person-focused rather than merely practical.

The Key Difference Between the Two Dimensions

Cognitive Empathy (Interpretations): Does the response show it understands what the person is feeling and experiencing? It is about recognizing and communicating the person's inner experience.

Affective Empathy (Emotional Reactions): Does the response express warmth, care, and compassion toward the person? It is about the emotional quality directed at the person.

A response can be warm without understanding, or understanding without warmth. Always rate the two dimensions independently, and always base your score on the full response.

Before you begin: Read each response carefully, consider how the person sharing it might experience it, and assign two scores from 0 to 10, one for Cognitive Empathy and one for Affective Empathy. There are no predetermined correct answers; please apply these guidelines consistently across all responses you rate. You may download the training guide by clicking [this link](#) for easy reference throughout the scoring: